

Victoria Free Public Transport Initiative 2026

Technical Report 1.0

Evaluation of the Free Public Transport Period: 31 March – 31 May 2026

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Executive Summary

In response to a fuel price shock and growing cost-of-living pressures, the Victorian Government introduced a temporary free public transport initiative between 31 March and 31 May 2026. The policy represented one of the largest public transport fare interventions undertaken in Australia and was designed primarily to provide financial relief to households facing rising transport costs.

This technical report presents the first phase of an ongoing evaluation examining the impacts of the free public transport period on travel behaviour, public transport use and road traffic conditions across Melbourne. The evaluation combines evidence from a statewide survey of 1,028 Victorian residents and traffic monitoring data collected across five major Melbourne transport corridors: Eastern Corridor, Monash Freeway, Nepean Highway, Tullamarine Freeway and the West Gate corridor.

The survey results indicate that the policy influenced travel behaviour for a substantial proportion of Victorians. Approximately 39.5% of respondents reported increasing their public transport use during the free fare period, while 38.2% reported replacing at least some car trips with public transport. Almost 29% reported reducing their car use. Strong public support was observed for transport affordability measures, with 77.4% of respondents agreeing that governments should provide affordable public transport options during periods of economic pressure.

Analysis of traffic data revealed more modest and spatially variable impacts. Four of the five monitored corridors recorded lower traffic volumes than their matched March baseline, with the largest reduction observed on the Tullamarine corridor, at 6.4% below baseline. Smaller reductions were observed on the Monash, Eastern and Nepean corridors, at 3.2%, 2.2% and 1.3% below baseline, respectively. The West Gate corridor recorded a modest increase of 3.1%, likely reflecting freight, logistics and industrial travel patterns that are less responsive to public transport pricing interventions.

The findings suggest that while free public transport encouraged experimentation with public transport and reduced some private vehicle travel, the resulting traffic impacts were modest and unevenly distributed across the road network. This outcome reflects the complexity of travel behaviour, which often changes gradually over time and is influenced by factors beyond transport cost alone, including service quality, travel time, convenience and trip purpose. It is also important to recognise that the initiative was introduced primarily as a cost-of-living measure rather than a congestion reduction strategy.

Survey respondents generally viewed the initiative positively but also highlighted persistent concerns regarding service frequency, reliability, overcrowding and passenger comfort. These findings suggest that fare reductions alone are unlikely to generate large-scale shifts

away from private vehicles unless accompanied by continued investment in service quality, network capacity and operational reliability.

The report concludes that the free public transport period produced measurable behavioural changes and provided valuable financial relief to many Victorian households. However, the long-term impacts remain uncertain. Victoria's subsequent transition to a 50% fare reduction for the remainder of 2026 provides a unique opportunity to examine whether the behavioural changes observed during the free fare period translate into sustained changes in travel behaviour over a longer timeframe.

This report represents the first phase of an ongoing evaluation. Additional analyses incorporating continued traffic monitoring, public transport operational data and other data sources will be reported as they become available throughout 2026.

1 Introduction

1.1 Background

Transport affordability has recently emerged as an increasingly important public policy issue in Australia. Rising fuel prices, inflationary pressures and broader increases in household living costs have placed growing financial pressure on many households, particularly those that rely heavily on private vehicles for daily travel.

In early 2026, escalating global fuel prices contributed to a significant increase in retail petrol prices across Australia. In response, the Victorian Government introduced a temporary free public transport initiative between 31 March and 31 May 2026. The policy removed fares across metropolitan and regional public transport services and aimed to provide immediate financial relief to households and maintain affordable access to employment, education and essential services.

Although the policy was primarily framed as a cost-of-living measure, it also created a rare opportunity to examine how travellers respond when a major financial barrier to public transport use is temporarily removed. Such large-scale fare interventions are uncommon especially when implemented across an entire state transport network.

The Victorian initiative therefore represents a valuable natural experiment for understanding travel behaviour, public transport demand and broader transport system responses to pricing interventions.

1.2 Study Significance

The effectiveness of fare-free public transport policies remains the subject of ongoing international debate.

Proponents argue that removing fares can increase accessibility, improve social equity, encourage public transport use and reduce household transport costs. Critics argue that fare removal alone may have limited impacts on private vehicle use and can impose substantial financial costs on governments.

Most existing evidence focuses on individual cities or localised fare-free initiatives. Comparatively little evidence exists regarding statewide fare interventions operating across large and diverse transport networks.

Victoria's 2026 initiative therefore provides an opportunity to examine several important policy questions:

- Do travellers increase their use of public transport when fares are removed?
- Does increased public transport use translate into reduced private vehicle travel?
- Are traffic impacts observable across major transport corridors?
- What factors influence behavioural responses to fare-free public transport?
- Are any behavioural changes likely to persist beyond the free fare period?

Answering these questions is important not only for evaluating the Victorian initiative but also for informing future discussions regarding transport affordability, fare reform and sustainable mobility policies.

1.3 Study Objectives

The overarching objective of this study is to evaluate the impacts of Victoria's temporary free public transport initiative on travel behaviour and traffic conditions.

The specific objectives are to:

1. Assess changes in public transport use during the free fare period.
2. Examine the extent to which public transport use substituted for private vehicle travel.
3. Quantify traffic impacts across major Melbourne transport corridors.
4. Identify the key factors influencing behavioural responses to the policy.
5. Evaluate public perceptions of the initiative and public transport service quality.
6. Establish a baseline for ongoing monitoring during the subsequent 50% fare reduction period.

1.4 Scope of Report

This report focuses on the initial free public transport period between 31 March and 31 May 2026.

The analysis draws upon a statewide survey of Victorian residents and traffic monitoring data collected from five major Melbourne transport corridors. These data sources provide both behavioural and objective measures of transport system response during the policy period.

The report forms the first phase of a broader longitudinal evaluation that will continue throughout 2026. Future reports will examine whether the behavioural and traffic changes observed during the free fare period persist during the subsequent discounted fare phase and whether longer-term changes in travel behaviour emerge over time.

2 Study Design and Data Sources

2.1 Research Design

This study adopted a mixed-methods evaluation framework combining behavioural and operational data sources to assess the impacts of Victoria’s free public transport initiative between 31 March and 31 May 2026.

The evaluation was designed around two complementary evidence streams. The first comprised a statewide survey of Victorian residents undertaken during the final week of the free public transport period, which captured self-reported travel behaviour, perceptions of the policy, attitudes towards transport affordability and intended future travel behaviour. The second comprised objective traffic monitoring data collected across five major Melbourne transport corridors using established traffic monitoring systems.

Combining survey and traffic datasets enabled both behavioural and observed transport system responses to be examined. Survey data provided insights into why travellers changed behaviour, while traffic monitoring data provided objective measurements of changes in road use during the policy period.

Figure 1 summarises the overall evaluation framework adopted in this study. Further details regarding project documentation, data management procedures, audit records and supplementary outputs are available through the project’s public GitHub repository (Dia, 2026a) and (Dia, 2026b).

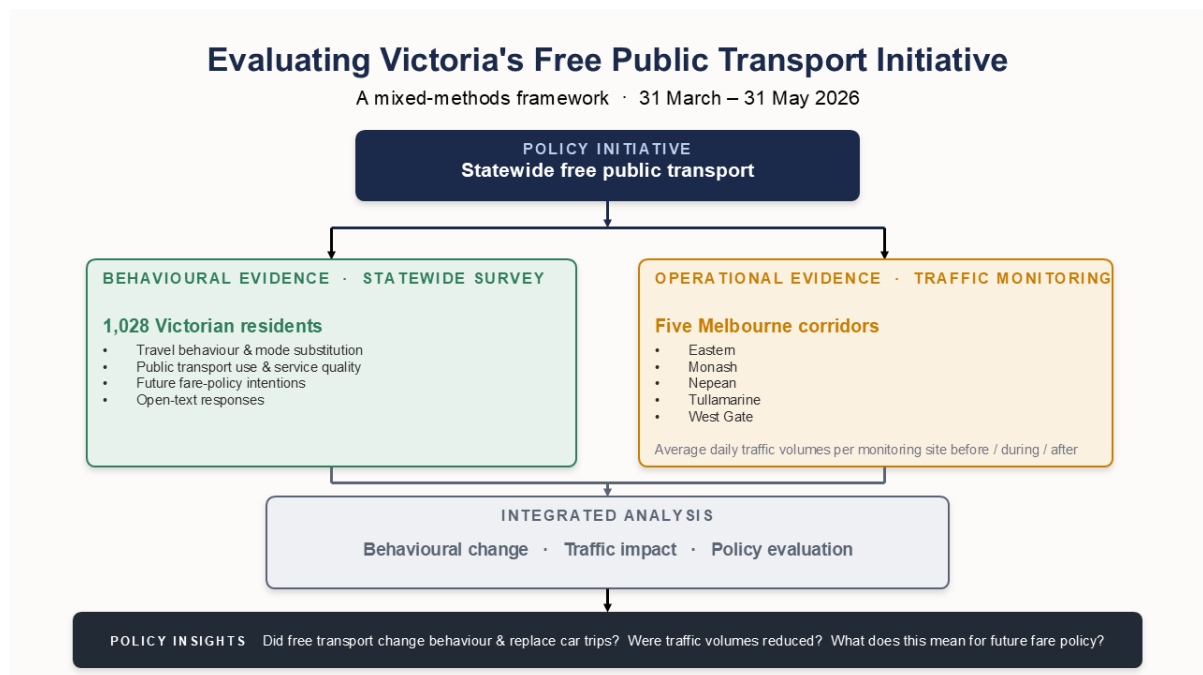


Figure 1: Study evaluation framework.

2.2 Survey Data Collection

A statewide online survey was conducted during the last week of May 2026 to assess behavioural responses to the free public transport initiative.

Participation was restricted to Victorian residents aged 18 years and over. The survey collected information on travel behaviour before and during the free public transport period, public transport use, private vehicle use, mode substitution, attitudes towards transport affordability measures, future travel intentions and perceptions of public transport service quality.

Following data cleaning and eligibility screening, the final analytical sample comprised 1,028 respondents distributed across metropolitan Melbourne and regional Victoria.

Figure 2 summarises the demographic profile of survey participants. The sample achieved broad demographic coverage across age groups, employment categories, household income levels and geographic locations. Responses were obtained from both metropolitan and regional areas, providing a diverse range of perspectives regarding the free public transport initiative.

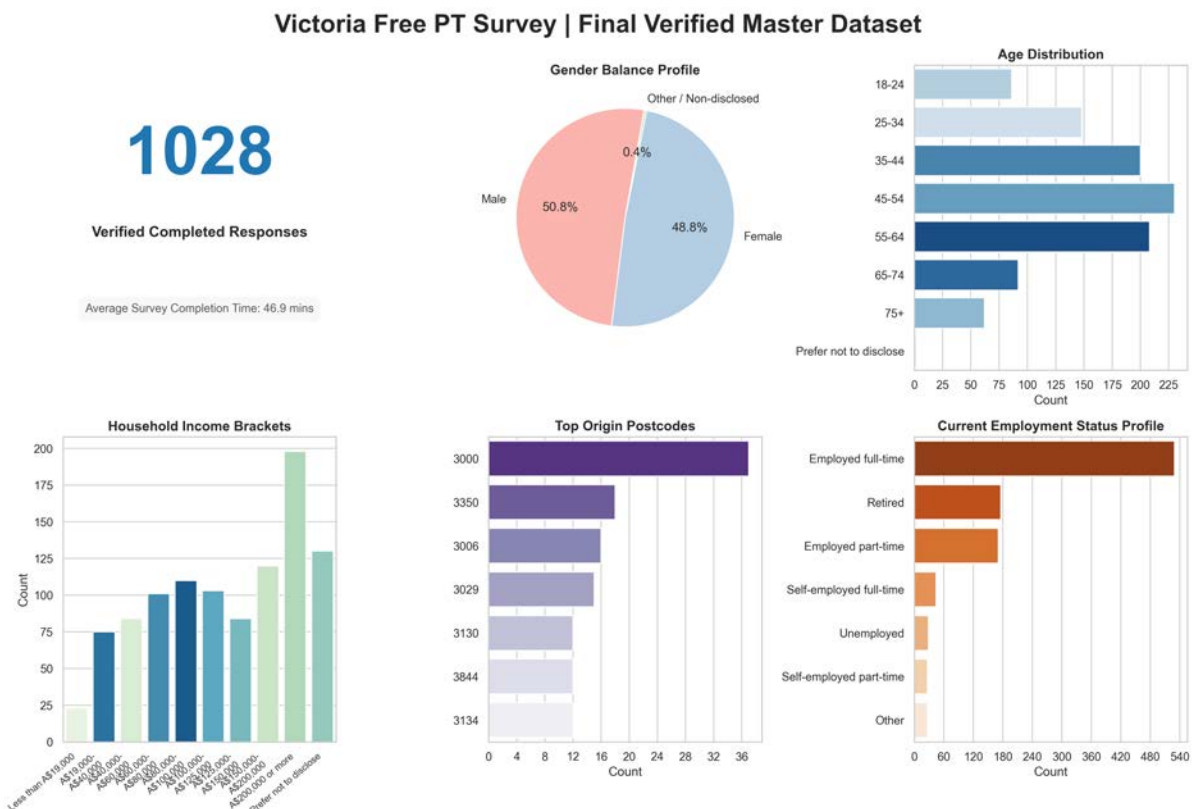


Figure 2: Demographic profile of survey respondents ($n = 1,028$).

2.3 Traffic Monitoring Data

Traffic impacts were assessed using data from two independent traffic monitoring systems: the Sydney Coordinated Adaptive Traffic System (SCATS) used on arterial corridors, and TIRTL traffic monitoring stations used on freeways. This data is publicly available from Transport Victoria OpenData portal (Transport Victoria, 2026).

Five major Melbourne transport corridors were selected for analysis:

- Eastern Freeway corridor (SCATS)
- Nepean Highway corridor (SCATS)
- Monash Freeway corridor (TIRTL)
- Tullamarine Freeway corridor (TIRTL)
- West Gate corridor (TIRTL)

These corridors were selected because they represent key commuter, freight and airport access routes and collectively capture a substantial proportion of Melbourne’s daily vehicle movements. The traffic monitoring locations used in the analysis are shown in Figure 3. These include 241 detector sites (37 SCATS and 204 TIRTL sites). The next stage of the study will extend data coverage by including more detection stations.

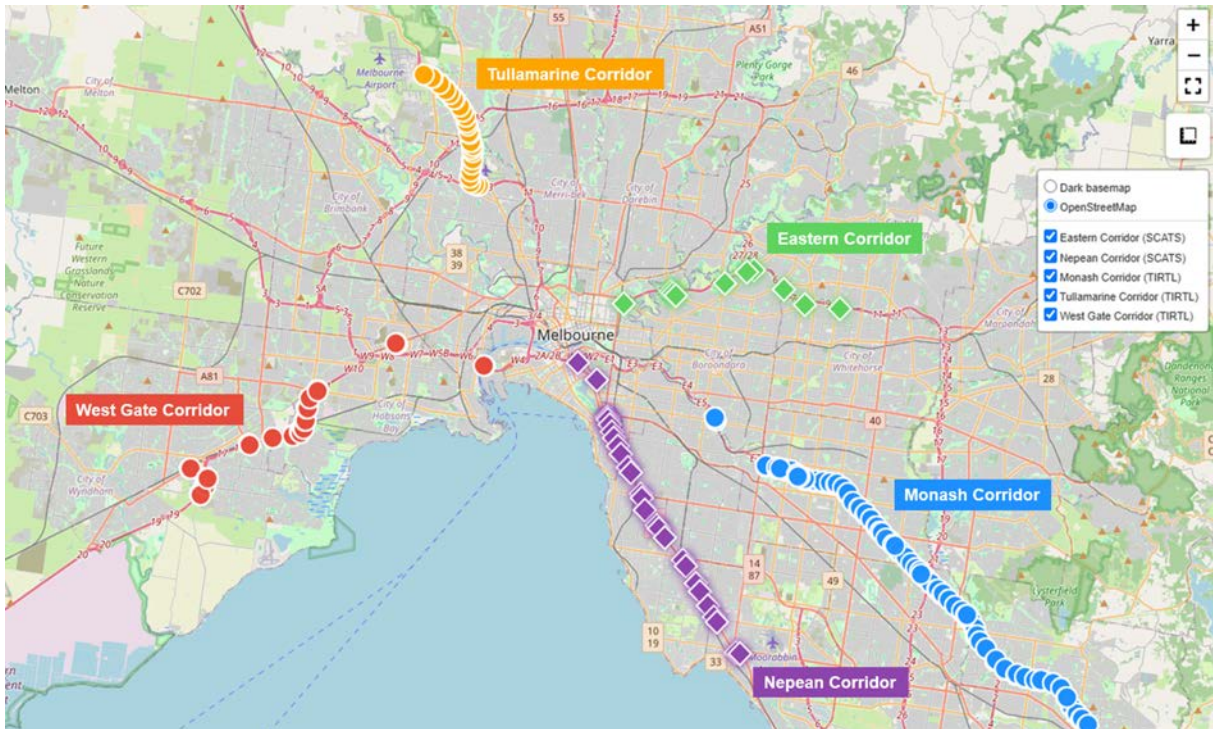


Figure 3: Locations of traffic monitoring sites.

For each corridor, daily traffic volumes were derived from multiple monitoring sites. To ensure consistency across corridors, traffic volumes were expressed as average daily vehicle movements per active monitoring site rather than aggregate corridor totals. This approach minimised biases associated with differences in corridor length, detector density and monitoring coverage.

2.4 Data Processing and Quality Assurance

Traffic and survey datasets were subjected to a structured quality assurance process prior to analysis.

For survey data, eligibility screening removed respondents who did not meet state residency or participation requirements. Postcode validation procedures identified two records containing likely data-entry errors, which were corrected in the analytical dataset while preserving the original raw data. All modifications were documented through a formal audit trail.

For traffic data, baseline and policy-period analyses were harmonised across all corridors. Daily traffic volumes were normalised using active detector counts to ensure consistency between corridors and across monitoring systems. Baseline traffic conditions were calculated using matched day-of-week comparisons from March 2026 to minimise the influence of weekly travel patterns.

Public holidays, Easter holidays and school holiday periods were identified separately to allow sensitivity testing and interpretation of temporal effects.

The resulting datasets provide a consistent basis for comparing traffic conditions before, during and after the free public transport period.

2.5 Study Limitations

Several limitations should be acknowledged.

First, survey responses were self-reported and may be subject to recall bias. Second, the evaluation period was limited to the first two months of the policy initiative. Third, observed traffic changes may have been influenced by external factors including fuel prices, seasonal travel patterns, weather conditions and broader economic activity.

Accordingly, the findings should be interpreted as evidence of associations observed during the free public transport period rather than definitive causal estimates of policy impact.

3 Survey Findings

This section presents the main survey findings from the final analytical sample of 1,028 Victorian residents. The analysis examines reported changes in public transport use, private vehicle use, car-to-public-transport substitution, drivers of behavioural change, perceptions of public transport service quality, future travel intentions and open-text feedback.

The survey results provide evidence that the free public transport period influenced travel behaviour for a substantial proportion of respondents. However, the findings also indicate that behavioural responses were heterogeneous and shaped by multiple interacting factors, including fare removal, increased fuel prices, public transport convenience, service quality and individual household circumstances.

3.1 Mode Substitution and Behavioural Change

A central objective of the survey was to assess whether the free public transport period encouraged respondents to shift some travel away from private vehicles and towards public transport. Figure 4 summarises reported changes in public transport use, private car use and car-to-public-transport substitution during the free fare period.

The results show clear evidence of behavioural change. Overall, 39.5% of respondents reported increasing their public transport use during the free fare period. A substantial proportion of respondents also reported replacing at least some private car trips with public transport. In total, 38.2% indicated that they substituted one or more car trips with public transport during the policy period. Among respondents who substituted car trips, most replaced between one and five car trips per week, suggesting that the policy encouraged selective substitution rather than wholesale abandonment of private vehicle travel.

Changes in private car use were more modest. Approximately 28.8% of respondents reported reducing their car use, while a larger share reported no change. This distinction is important: the policy appears to have encouraged greater public transport use and some car-trip substitution, but this did not necessarily translate into large reductions in total car use for all respondents.

The findings therefore indicate that the free fare period produced a measurable behavioural response, but that the response was partial, selective and uneven across the population.

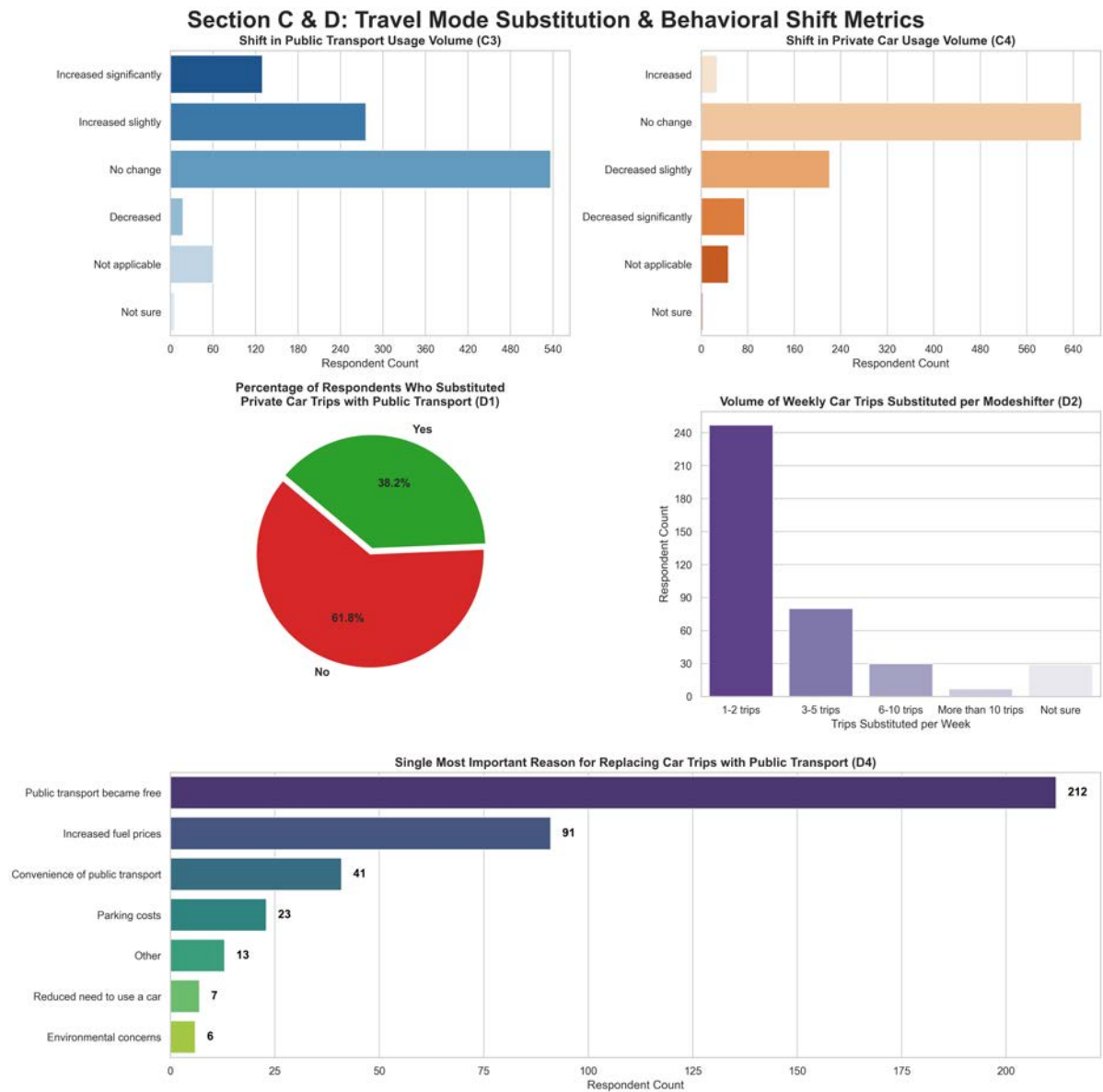


Figure 4: Changes in public transport use, car use and mode substitution during the free public transport period.

3.2 Drivers of Travel Behaviour Change

The survey also asked respondents to identify the main factors influencing changes in their travel behaviour. These responses help interpret whether behavioural changes were primarily driven by fare removal, fuel prices, convenience or other contextual factors. Figure 5 presents the most important factors reported by respondents.

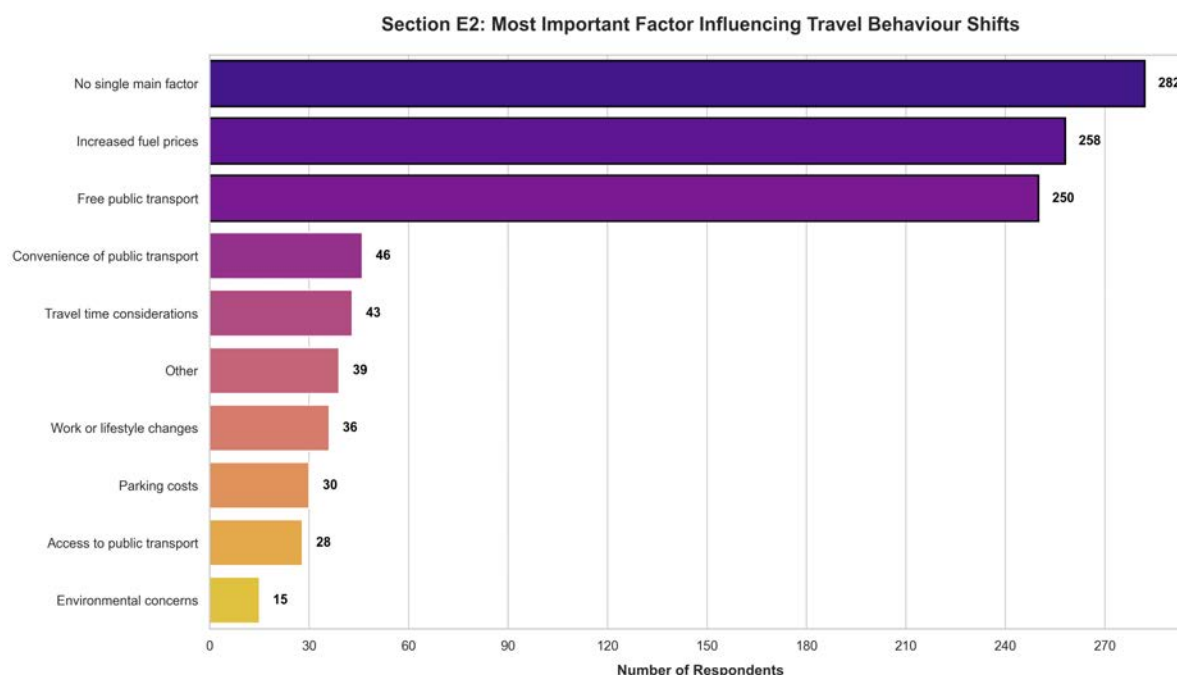


Figure 5: Most important factors influencing reported travel behaviour changes during the free public transport period.

The largest response category was “No single main factor”, selected by 282 respondents. This indicates that travel decisions during the study period were shaped by multiple influences rather than a single dominant cause.

Among specific factors, increased fuel prices and free public transport were the most frequently cited drivers of behavioural change, with 258 and 250 responses, respectively. This suggests that travel responses occurred within a broader economic context. The survey findings indicate that free public transport may have encouraged some residents to trial public transport more frequently, while higher fuel costs strengthened the financial attractiveness of alternatives to private vehicle travel.

Other factors, including public transport convenience, travel time considerations, work and lifestyle changes, parking costs and access to public transport, were less frequently selected but remain analytically important. These factors demonstrate that the effectiveness of fare interventions depends not only on price but also on the broader usability and practicality of the public transport system.

The findings suggest that free public transport was an important driver of behaviour change, but not the only one. Behavioural responses were shaped by the interaction between transport affordability, fuel costs, service convenience and individual circumstances.

3.3 Public Transport Experience and Service Quality

The survey assessed respondent perceptions of public transport service quality during the free fare period. These measures are important because the long-term success of fare interventions depends not only on attracting new passengers, but also on whether service quality is sufficient to retain them.

Figure 6 summarises respondent evaluations of key public transport service attributes, excluding respondents who selected “Not applicable”.

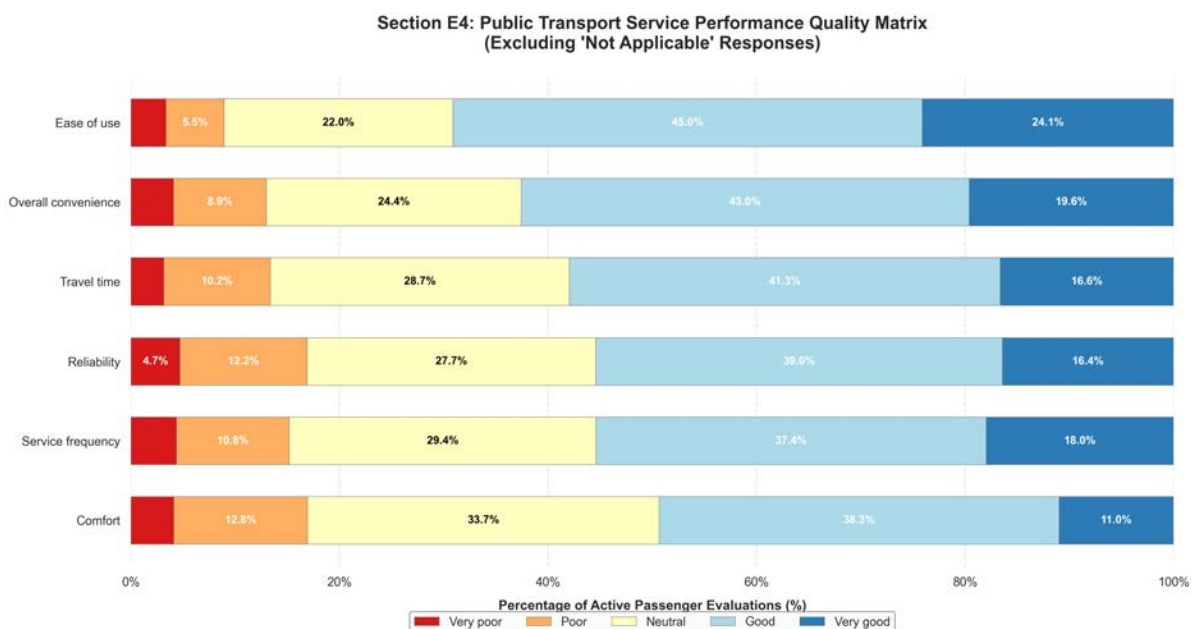


Figure 6: Passenger evaluation of public transport service attributes during the free public transport period.

Respondents generally reported positive perceptions of public transport services. Ease of use received the strongest ratings, with approximately 69% of active users rating it as good or very good. Overall convenience, travel time and reliability also received predominantly positive assessments.

However, the results also reveal areas of concern. Comfort recorded the lowest proportion of very good ratings, while service frequency and reliability attracted higher levels of dissatisfaction than other attributes. These results are consistent with open-text comments in which respondents raised concerns about crowding, difficulty finding seats, service delays and replacement buses.

The findings suggest that fare removal can encourage public transport use, but service quality remains a critical determinant of whether behavioural change can be sustained. If increased demand is not matched by sufficient capacity, reliability and comfort, some users may return to private vehicles once fares are reinstated or partially reinstated.

3.4 Future Travel Behaviour and Policy Implications

An important question for this evaluation is whether the behavioural changes observed during the free fare period are likely to persist.

Figure 7 summarises respondent expectations regarding future travel behaviour, confidence in maintaining higher public transport use, interest in fare reform options and support for affordability-related transport policies.

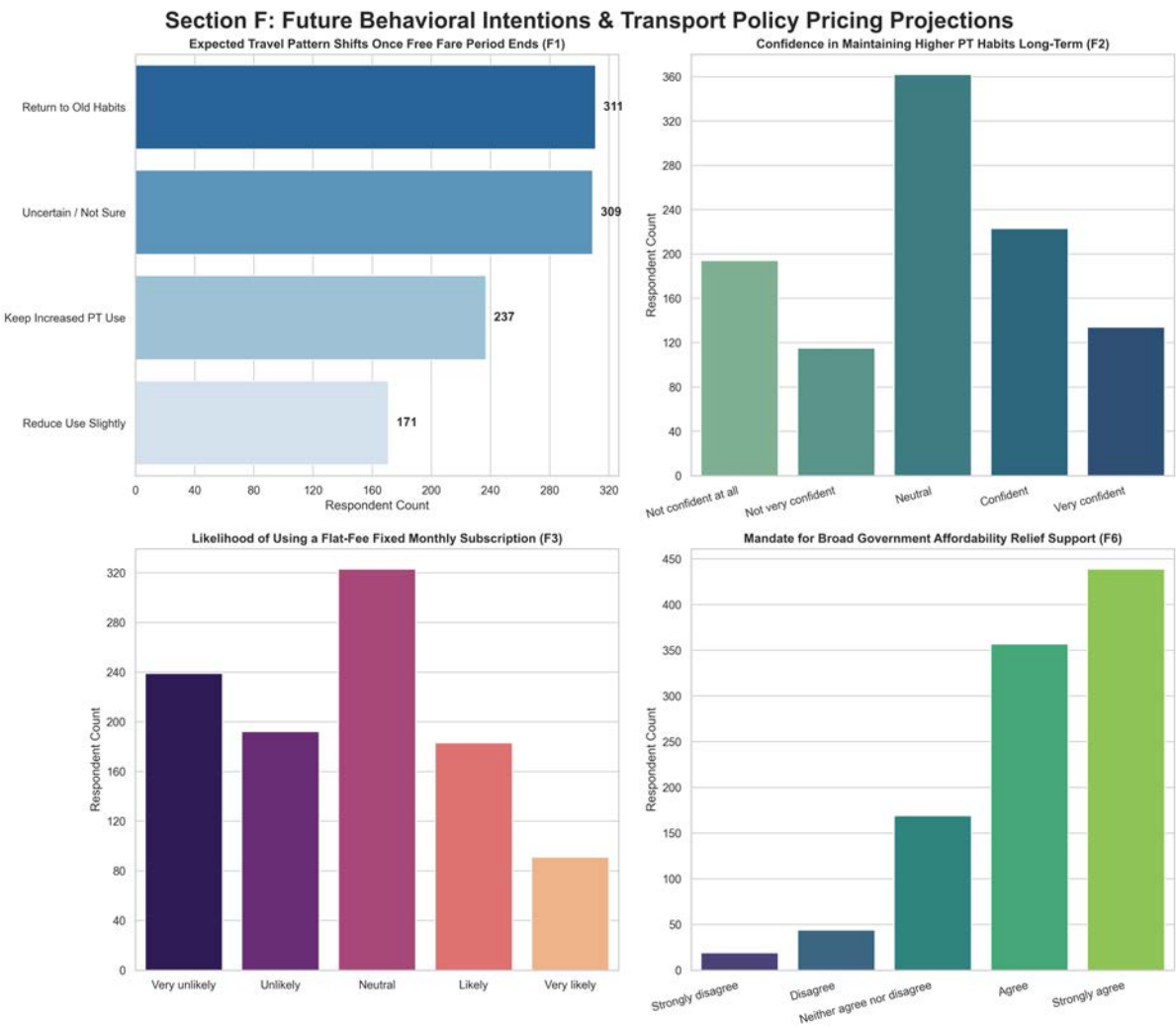


Figure 7: Future travel intentions and attitudes towards public transport affordability policies.

Respondents expressed mixed expectations about their future travel behaviour once the

free fare period ended. A large group anticipated returning to previous travel patterns, while a substantial number expected to continue using public transport more than before the policy period. A similarly large group remained uncertain.

This uncertainty is analytically important. It suggests that the free fare period may have encouraged experimentation with public transport, but that longer-term behavioural change had not yet stabilised by the end of the policy period.

Confidence in maintaining higher public transport use was moderate overall. Many respondents selected neutral or uncertain responses, indicating that future behaviour may depend on external conditions such as fare levels, service quality, fuel prices, work arrangements and household travel needs.

The survey also found strong support for affordability-focused public transport policies. Most respondents agreed or strongly agreed that governments should provide affordable public transport measures during periods of economic pressure. This finding reinforces the interpretation that the free fare period was broadly welcomed as a cost-of-living intervention, even if its traffic impacts were more modest.

These results support the need for continued monitoring during the subsequent 50% fare reduction period. The discounted fare phase provides an opportunity to examine whether the behavioural shifts observed during the free fare period persist once public transport is no longer free but remains substantially cheaper than usual.

3.5 Qualitative Insights from Open-Text Responses

The survey included open-text questions that allowed respondents to provide additional comments about the free public transport initiative and their travel experiences. These responses provide important qualitative context for interpreting the structured survey results.

Figure 8 summarises the major themes identified through thematic analysis of substantive open-text comments.

The most frequently occurring theme involved positive endorsement of the initiative and support for extending affordable public transport measures. Many respondents highlighted cost-of-living benefits, increased mobility and improved access to employment, education and social activities.

A second prominent theme related to fiscal prudence. Some respondents supported the initiative but raised questions about its cost, funding model and long-term sustainability. This indicates that public support for affordability measures does not necessarily imply unconditional support for permanent fare-free public transport.

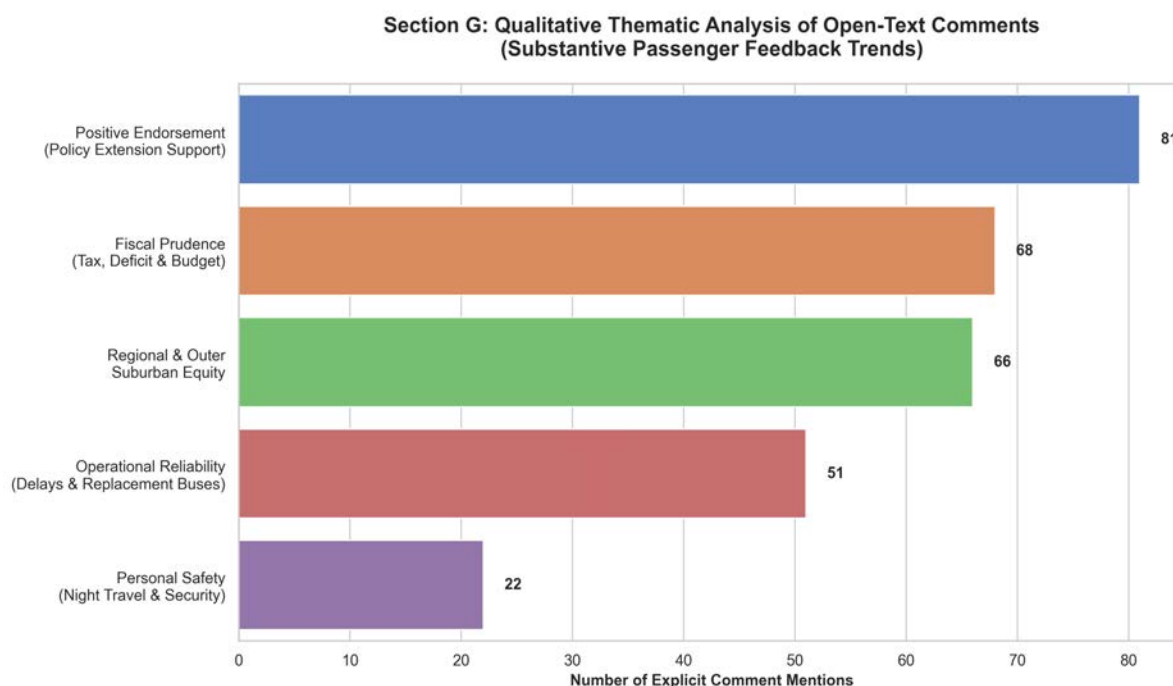


Figure 8: Major themes identified from qualitative analysis of respondent comments.

Regional and outer suburban equity also emerged as a major theme. Respondents from areas with limited public transport access noted that the benefits of free fares were unevenly distributed. This finding is important because fare removal primarily benefits people who already have access to usable public transport services.

Operational reliability was another common concern. Respondents referred to delays, service disruptions, replacement buses, crowding and reduced comfort. These comments align with the quantitative service quality findings and reinforce the importance of capacity and reliability in shaping longer-term mode shift.

A smaller but important set of comments raised personal safety concerns, particularly in relation to night travel, station environments and perceived security.

Overall, the qualitative findings reinforce the broader survey results. The initiative was widely welcomed, but respondents also identified important constraints relating to service quality, reliability, comfort, equity and fiscal sustainability.

3.6 Summary of Survey Findings

The survey findings indicate that Victoria's free public transport period produced measurable changes in reported travel behaviour. A substantial share of respondents increased their public transport use, and more than one-third replaced at least some car trips with public transport.

However, the evidence also shows that these changes were partial rather than universal. Many respondents reported no change in car use, and future travel intentions remained uncertain for a large share of the sample.

The main behavioural drivers were not limited to fare removal. Increased fuel prices, public transport convenience, travel time considerations, work and lifestyle factors, and access to services all influenced travel decisions.

The policy was strongly supported as a cost-of-living measure, but the survey also highlighted long-standing public transport challenges, particularly overcrowding, comfort, frequency, reliability and regional equity.

Overall, the survey results suggest that fare reductions can encourage public transport experimentation and selected car-trip substitution, but sustained mode shift is likely to require complementary improvements in service quality, network coverage and capacity.

4 Traffic Analysis Results

This section of the report presents the results of the traffic analysis component of the study. Traffic volumes during the free public transport period (April and May 2026) were compared against matched March 2026 baseline conditions using harmonised monitoring procedures across five major Melbourne transport corridors.

The analysis was designed to assess whether behavioural changes reported by survey respondents were reflected in observable changes in traffic conditions across Melbourne’s road network.

4.1 Overview of Corridor-Level Traffic Changes

Table 1 summarises average traffic changes observed across the five monitored corridors during the free public transport period.

The corridor summary includes two complementary measures of traffic change. The “Average Change” column reports the mean percentage difference between observed traffic volumes and matched March baseline conditions across the full evaluation period after Easter exclusions. The “Post-Holiday Normal Period” column reports the corresponding average after major holiday effects had subsided, providing a robustness check for whether observed traffic changes persisted under more typical operating conditions. Comparing these two measures helps distinguish temporary holiday-related fluctuations from more sustained behavioural responses.

The results indicate that traffic impacts were generally modest and varied considerably across the network.

Four of the five monitored corridors recorded lower traffic volumes than their matched March baseline conditions. The largest reduction was observed on the Tullamarine corridor, where average traffic volumes were approximately 6.4% below baseline levels. Smaller reductions were observed on the Monash, Eastern and Nepean corridors.

The West Gate corridor was the only corridor to record an increase in traffic volumes, averaging approximately 3.1% above baseline conditions.

The confidence intervals (CI) indicate that traffic reductions on the Eastern, Monash, Nepean and Tullamarine corridors were consistently below matched March baseline conditions. In contrast, the confidence interval for the West Gate corridor spans both positive and negative values, indicating greater uncertainty regarding the direction and magnitude of observed change.

Table 1: Average traffic change during the free public transport period (Easter period excluded).

Corridor	Source	Days Analysed	Average Change	95% Confidence Interval	Post-Holiday Normal Period	% Days Below Baseline	Interpretation
Eastern	SCATS	57	-2.2%	-3.7% to -0.8%	+0.0%	67%	Likely below baseline
Monash	TIRTL	56	-3.2%	-4.3% to -2.2%	-3.1%	88%	Likely below baseline
Nepean	SCATS	57	-1.3%	-2.2% to -0.4%	-0.0%	67%	Likely below baseline
Tullamarine	TIRTL	56	-6.4%	-7.3% to -5.5%	-7.2%	96%	Likely below baseline
West Gate	TIRTL	56	+3.0%	-1.0% to +7.0%	+9.9%	30%	Near baseline or inconclusive

The comparison between the overall evaluation period and the post-holiday normal period reveals important differences across corridors. For some corridors, particularly Tullamarine and Monash, traffic reductions remained evident after holiday effects were removed, suggesting a more persistent change in travel behaviour. In contrast, reductions on the Eastern and Nepean corridors largely disappeared during the post-holiday period, indicating that earlier reductions may have been influenced by seasonal travel patterns. The West Gate corridor exhibited the opposite effect, with traffic growth becoming more pronounced during normal operating conditions.

These findings suggest that while some behavioural shifts away from private vehicle travel occurred during the free fare period, the resulting traffic impacts were neither uniform nor large enough to produce substantial network-wide reductions in traffic volumes.

4.2 Changes in Average Traffic Volumes

Percentage changes provide useful indicators of relative impacts but do not necessarily convey the magnitude of observed traffic changes. Examining actual traffic volumes per monitoring site (Table 2) provides additional context.

Table 2: Average daily traffic volumes (vehicles per day) per active monitoring site during the evaluation period.

Corridor	Baseline March Volume/Site	Observed April-May Volume/Site	Difference (veh/day/site)	Percentage Change	Days Analysed
Eastern	58,154	56,861	-1,293	-2.2%	57
Monash	83,765	81,094	-2,671	-3.2%	56
Nepean	71,184	70,251	-933	-1.3%	57
Tullamarine	53,327	49,903	-3,424	-6.4%	56
West Gate	41,795	43,087	+1,292	+3.1%	56

The average daily traffic volumes per active monitoring site shown in Table 2 reveal substantial variation across Melbourne’s major transport corridors. The largest reduction was observed on the Tullamarine corridor, where average daily traffic volumes declined by approximately 3,424 vehicles per active monitoring site relative to matched March baseline conditions. The Monash corridor recorded the second largest reduction, with volumes decreasing by approximately 2,671 vehicles per site per day. Smaller but still measurable reductions were observed on the Eastern and Nepean corridors.

In contrast, the West Gate corridor exhibited a different pattern, recording an increase of approximately 1,292 vehicles per site per day during the free public transport period. This result is consistent with the corridor’s significant freight, logistics and industrial transport function, which is likely to be less responsive to public transport fare interventions than commuter-oriented corridors.

Importantly, these values represent average daily vehicle movements per active monitoring site and should not be interpreted as total vehicle reductions across Melbourne’s road network. The metric provides a standardised basis for comparing traffic conditions across corridors with differing numbers of monitoring sites and detector configurations.

4.3 Peak Period and Temporal Patterns

Table 3 shows that traffic responses varied by time of day and by weekday/weekend classification. AM peak reductions were observed on four of the five monitored corridors, with the largest AM peak reductions occurring on the Eastern and Nepean corridors. PM peak effects were weaker and more mixed, with several corridors recording small increases.

Table 3: Average traffic changes by peak period and weekday/weekend classification during the free public transport period.

Corridor	AM Peak	PM Peak	Weekday	Weekend
Eastern	-2.6%	+0.3%	-2.4%	-1.7%
Monash	-1.1%	-1.6%	-2.4%	-5.6%
Nepean	-2.5%	+1.1%	-1.5%	-0.8%
Tullamarine	-1.8%	+1.0%	-6.4%	-6.5%
West Gate	+2.7%	+9.1%	+4.7%	-1.6%

Note: Values represent percentage changes in traffic volume during the free public transport period relative to matched March baseline conditions.

Weekday traffic reductions were evident on the Eastern, Monash, Nepean and Tullamarine corridors, while the West Gate corridor recorded an increase. Weekend patterns differed, with stronger reductions on the Monash and Tullamarine corridors and a weekend decline on the West Gate corridor.

These results suggest that the free public transport period did not produce a uniform traffic response across all travel periods. Reductions were more evident on some corridors and during some periods, while other corridors, particularly West Gate, displayed patterns likely influenced by freight, logistics and industrial activity.

4.4 Day-of-Week Effects

To better understand temporal variation, traffic changes were examined separately for each day of the week after excluding Easter holiday effects. Figure 9 presents average traffic changes by corridor and day of week. Several notable patterns emerge.

The Tullamarine corridor recorded consistent reductions throughout the week, with traffic volumes generally between 5% and 8% below baseline conditions.

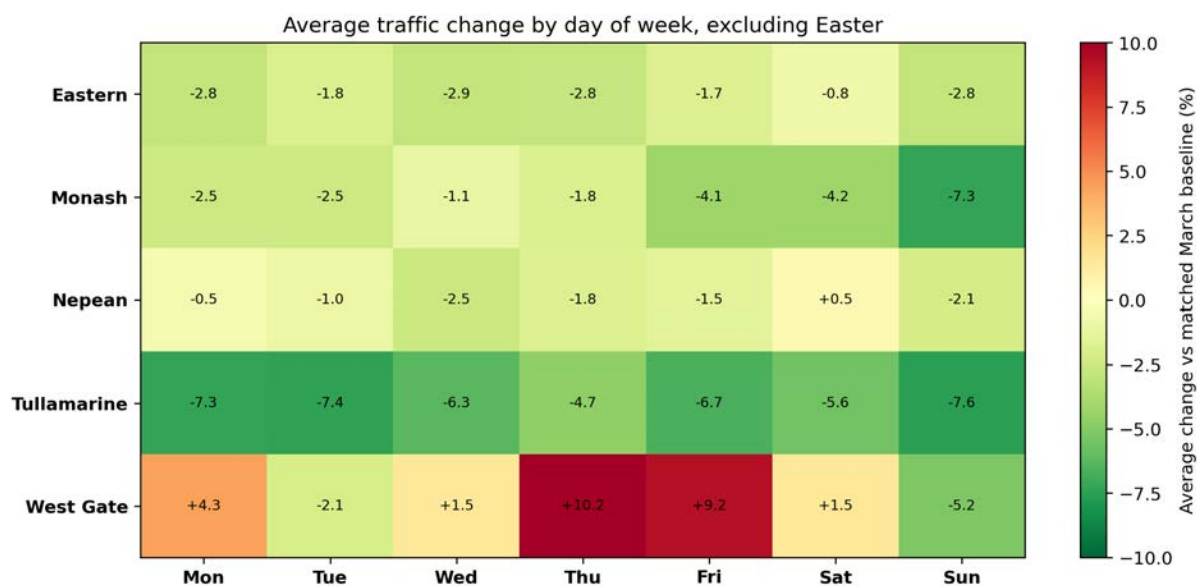


Figure 9: Average traffic change by corridor and day of week.

The Monash corridor also recorded reductions across all days, although the magnitude varied considerably.

The Eastern and Nepean corridors exhibited relatively stable but modest reductions throughout the week.

The West Gate corridor displayed the most distinctive pattern. Traffic volumes increased substantially on several weekdays, particularly Thursday and Friday, while Sunday traffic remained below baseline levels. This reinforces the interpretation that freight and industrial activity influenced corridor-specific outcomes.

4.5 Interpretation of Traffic Outcomes

The traffic results provide a more complex picture than might be expected from the behavioural survey findings alone.

Survey responses indicated that many Victorians increased their use of public transport and reduced some private vehicle travel. However, the traffic analysis demonstrates that these behavioural changes translated into modest traffic impacts at the network level.

Several explanations are possible.

First, many respondents reported replacing only a small number of car trips each week rather than eliminating private vehicle use altogether.

Second, public transport appears to have been used frequently for discretionary and non-work trips, which may have limited its influence on weekday commuter traffic.

Third, many travel decisions remain constrained by factors such as workplace location, childcare responsibilities, service availability and network accessibility.

Finally, some corridors carry large volumes of freight, commercial and industrial traffic that are largely unaffected by public transport fare changes.

Taken together, these findings suggest that fare-free public transport can encourage behavioural change and increase public transport usage, but substantial reductions in road traffic are unlikely without broader changes in travel demand, service quality and urban accessibility.

4.6 Summary of Traffic Findings

The traffic analysis identified measurable but generally modest changes across Melbourne's monitored transport corridors during the free public transport period.

Four of the five monitored corridors recorded lower traffic volumes relative to matched March baseline conditions, with the strongest reductions occurring on the Tullamarine and Monash corridors.

Traffic reductions varied across days of the week and by time of day, indicating that behavioural responses were not uniform across the network.

The results support the conclusion that free public transport encouraged some travellers to reduce private vehicle use. However, the scale of observed traffic reductions suggests that fare removal alone is unlikely to generate large reductions in road traffic without complementary improvements in public transport service quality, reliability, coverage and capacity.

5 Discussion

This section of the report interprets the survey and traffic analysis findings within the broader context of transport policy, travel behaviour and public transport planning. While the preceding sections presented the empirical results, the discussion here focuses on their implications for understanding how travellers responded to Victoria’s free public transport initiative. Particular attention is given to the relationship between reported behavioural changes and observed traffic outcomes, the role of service quality in supporting longer-term mode shift, and the lessons that can be drawn from this large-scale natural experiment as Victoria transitions to a 50% fare reduction for the remainder of 2026.

5.1 Did Free Public Transport Change Travel Behaviour?

The combined survey and traffic findings indicate that Victoria’s free public transport initiative did influence travel behaviour during the evaluation period. A substantial proportion of survey respondents reported increasing their public transport use, replacing some car trips with public transport and reducing private vehicle travel.

These findings suggest that the removal of fares successfully reduced one of the key barriers to public transport use, namely direct out-of-pocket travel costs. For many households, particularly during a period of elevated fuel prices and broader cost-of-living pressures, free public transport provided a financially attractive alternative for at least some journeys.

Importantly, the survey evidence indicates that behavioural responses extended beyond existing public transport users. Many respondents reported using public transport for discretionary, recreational and social trips that may not otherwise have occurred. This suggests that fare removal not only influenced mode choice but also affected overall travel behaviour and trip-making decisions.

These findings suggest that fare-free public transport can stimulate increased public transport use and encourage experimentation with alternative travel modes, at least in the short term.

5.2 Why Were Traffic Impacts Modest?

While the survey findings demonstrate clear behavioural change, the traffic analysis revealed more modest impacts at the network level. This apparent discrepancy is an important finding rather than a contradiction.

Several factors help explain why substantial increases in reported public transport use did not translate into equally large reductions in road traffic.

First, many respondents reported replacing only a small number of car trips each week rather than eliminating private vehicle travel altogether. Partial substitution can generate noticeable changes in individual travel behaviour while producing relatively modest effects when aggregated across an entire metropolitan transport network.

Second, many of the trips shifted to public transport appear to have been discretionary rather than mandatory commuting trips. Survey responses suggest that free fares encouraged additional recreational, shopping and social travel. These trip types are often more flexible and therefore more responsive to fare incentives than regular work-related travel.

Third, many travel decisions remain constrained by factors unrelated to transport cost. Workplace location, childcare responsibilities, service availability, travel time, accessibility and personal preferences all influence mode choice. Removing fares does not eliminate these structural constraints.

Finally, some corridors, particularly the West Gate corridor, carry significant volumes of freight, logistics and commercial traffic that are largely unaffected by public transport pricing policies. These trips continue to occur regardless of fare levels and therefore limit the magnitude of network-wide traffic reductions that can reasonably be expected.

Overall, these findings suggest that fare-free public transport can contribute to reduced private vehicle use but is unlikely, in the short term, to generate large reductions in traffic volumes in isolation. Travel behaviour change typically occurs gradually and is influenced by a range of factors beyond transport cost alone, including service quality, reliability, convenience, accessibility and broader economic conditions. As a result, larger network-wide shifts in travel patterns may require sustained policy interventions and longer timeframes to emerge.

5.3 The Importance of Service Quality

One of the strongest findings emerging from both the quantitative and qualitative survey results is that price is only one component of transport choice.

Although respondents generally viewed the free public transport initiative positively, concerns regarding overcrowding, reliability, service frequency and passenger comfort were repeatedly identified throughout the survey. These concerns were evident in both structured service quality ratings and open-text responses.

This finding is significant because it suggests that attracting passengers and retaining passengers are not necessarily the same challenge. Fare reductions may encourage travellers to try public transport, but longer-term mode shift depends heavily on the quality of the travel experience.

The survey results indicate that many respondents remain uncertain about whether they will continue using public transport at higher levels once fares return or stabilise. This uncertainty suggests that future travel behaviour will depend not only on ticket prices but also on the quality, convenience and reliability of services available to passengers.

The results therefore support the view that fare policies and service quality improvements should be considered complementary rather than competing strategies.

5.4 Implications for Transport Policy

The Victorian free public transport initiative was introduced primarily as a cost-of-living measure rather than a congestion reduction strategy. From this perspective, the findings suggest that the policy achieved many of its intended objectives.

The survey indicates that the initiative provided financial relief to households, encouraged greater use of public transport and received strong public support. These outcomes are important in their own right regardless of whether substantial traffic reductions occurred.

However, the findings also highlight the limitations of relying solely on fare interventions to achieve broader transport system objectives such as congestion reduction or large-scale mode shift.

If governments wish to encourage sustained reductions in private vehicle use, fare policies are likely to be most effective when combined with investments in service frequency, reliability, network coverage, passenger comfort and overall system capacity.

The results also highlight important equity considerations. Respondents from regional and outer suburban areas noted that the benefits of fare-free public transport depend on having access to viable public transport services in the first place. This suggests that transport affordability policies should be considered alongside broader questions of network accessibility and service provision.

5.5 Lessons from the Victorian Natural Experiment

Large-scale fare-free public transport initiatives remain relatively uncommon at the national level, particularly when implemented across an entire state transport network. Victoria's 2026 initiative therefore provides a valuable real-world case study for researchers and policymakers.

The findings from this study demonstrate that behavioural responses to transport pricing interventions are often more complex than simple assumptions regarding mode shift. Public transport use can increase substantially even when traffic reductions remain modest.

Similarly, changes in travel behaviour may occur gradually and may not be immediately visible through traditional traffic indicators.

The study also highlights the importance of combining behavioural and operational datasets when evaluating transport policies. Survey data alone would suggest substantial behavioural change, while traffic data alone would suggest more modest impacts. Together, the two datasets provide a richer and more complete understanding of how travellers responded to the policy.

Most importantly, the findings demonstrate that transport affordability matters. For many households, the cost of travel remains an important determinant of mobility choices. The Victorian experiment provides evidence that reducing transport costs can influence behaviour, improve accessibility and encourage greater engagement with public transport systems.

The transition from fare-free travel to the subsequent 50% fare reduction period creates a unique opportunity to examine whether the behavioural changes observed during the free fare phase evolve into longer-term travel behaviour change. Continued monitoring throughout the remainder of 2026 will provide important insights into the persistence of these effects.

6 Limitations

This study has several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the findings. While the combination of survey and traffic monitoring data provides a robust basis for understanding behavioural and network-level responses to Victoria's free public transport initiative, the results should be interpreted within the context of the study design, available data sources and evaluation timeframe.

6.1 Observational Nature of the Study

The study was designed as an observational evaluation of a real-world policy intervention rather than a controlled experiment. Consequently, the analysis cannot establish definitive causal relationships between the free public transport initiative and the observed behavioural or traffic changes.

Although matched March baseline conditions, holiday exclusions and multiple data sources were used to improve the robustness of the analysis, other factors may also have influenced travel behaviour during the study period. These include fuel prices, weather conditions, economic activity, workplace attendance patterns, road incidents and broader seasonal effects.

The findings should therefore be interpreted as evidence of associations observed during the policy period rather than precise estimates of causal impact.

6.2 Survey Limitations

The behavioural findings are based on self-reported survey responses and are therefore subject to the limitations commonly associated with survey research.

Respondents may not always accurately recall past travel behaviour, and some responses may be influenced by social desirability bias, particularly when reporting environmentally or socially desirable behaviours such as increased public transport use.

Although the final sample comprised 1,028 Victorian residents and achieved broad geographic and demographic coverage, participation was voluntary and therefore may be subject to some degree of self-selection bias. Individuals with stronger views or greater interest in transport issues may have been more likely to participate. While the sample characteristics broadly reflected the diversity of the Victorian population, the findings should be interpreted as indicative of behavioural trends rather than precise population estimates.

6.3 Traffic Monitoring Limitations

The traffic analysis focused on five major Melbourne transport corridors selected to provide coverage across a range of commuter, airport, freight and mixed-use travel markets. While these corridors represent important components of Melbourne’s transport network, they do not capture all road travel occurring across the metropolitan area. Future phases of the research will seek to expand network coverage through the inclusion of additional detector locations along the existing corridors as well as supplementary routes that capture inner-urban, orbital and growth-area travel patterns.

Potential future additions include major inner-urban corridors such as Punt Road/Hoddle Street, orbital routes such as the M80 Ring Road, and growth-area corridors including the Calder and Princes freeways as well as other key routes such as Bell Street, Springvale Road and Burwood Highway. These additions would provide broader coverage of commuter, freight, regional and suburban travel markets across metropolitan Melbourne.

In addition, traffic volumes were analysed using a standardised metric based on average daily vehicle movements per active monitoring site. This approach improves comparability across corridors but does not provide direct estimates of total vehicle reductions across Melbourne’s road network.

Consequently, the traffic findings in this preliminary report should be interpreted as corridor-level indicators of network response rather than a comprehensive assessment of metropolitan-wide traffic conditions.

6.4 Evaluation Timeframe

The free public transport period analysed in this report lasted approximately two months. Behavioural change often occurs gradually, particularly when long-established travel habits are involved. As a result, some travellers may not have had sufficient time to fully adjust their travel patterns during the evaluation period.

The survey results indicate that many respondents remained uncertain about their future travel behaviour and whether they would continue using public transport at elevated levels once the free fare period ended. It is therefore possible that longer-term behavioural effects may differ from those observed during the initial phase of the policy.

Victoria’s transition to a 50% fare reduction for the remainder of 2026 provides a rare opportunity to examine whether the behavioural changes identified in this report persist, strengthen or diminish over time.

6.5 Future Research Opportunities

Several opportunities exist to extend the analysis presented in this report. Future phases of the evaluation will incorporate additional traffic monitoring data collected during the 50% fare reduction period and may be supplemented by public transport patronage data, mobility datasets and operational performance indicators as these become available.

The ongoing nature of the Victorian policy response creates an opportunity to examine behavioural adaptation over a longer timeframe and to better understand the relationship between transport affordability, public transport use and private vehicle travel.

Continued monitoring throughout 2026 will provide a richer evidence base for assessing the longer-term impacts of fare-based transport interventions and their implications for future transport policy.

7 Conclusions and Next Steps

This report presented the first evaluation of Victoria’s 2026 free public transport initiative using a combination of statewide survey data and corridor-level traffic monitoring. The study examined whether removing public transport fares influenced travel behaviour, public transport use and road traffic conditions during the two-month free fare period between April and May 2026. Preliminary findings from the first phase of the evaluation have also been communicated through a public-facing article intended to support broader community engagement with the project (Dia, 2026b).

7.1 Key Findings

The findings indicate that Victoria’s free public transport initiative influenced how many residents travelled during the evaluation period. Survey responses from 1,028 Victorian residents revealed substantial behavioural change, with 39.5% reporting increased public transport use, 38.2% indicating that they had replaced at least some car trips with public transport, and almost 30% reporting a reduction in overall private vehicle use. These results suggest that the removal of fares encouraged many travellers to reconsider established travel habits and experiment with alternative transport options.

The survey also highlighted the importance of the broader economic context in which the policy was introduced. Increased fuel prices and free public transport were identified as the two most influential drivers of behavioural change, indicating that many households were responding to a combination of transport affordability pressures rather than the fare-free initiative alone. Strong public support for affordable public transport measures further reinforces the importance of transport costs in shaping travel decisions during periods of economic uncertainty.

The traffic analysis provided an important complementary perspective. Four of the five monitored corridors recorded lower traffic volumes relative to matched March baseline conditions, although the magnitude of change varied considerably across the network. The largest reductions occurred on the Tullamarine and Monash corridors, while the West Gate corridor exhibited a different pattern characterised by stable or increased traffic volumes, likely reflecting its significant freight and industrial transport function.

The survey and traffic findings suggest that the policy encouraged meaningful behavioural change and increased public transport use, but that these changes translated into more modest network-level traffic impacts in the short term. This highlights the complexity of travel behaviour and demonstrates that increased public transport use does not necessarily produce immediate or uniform reductions in road traffic. The findings also suggest that while fare-free public transport can influence travel choices, longer-term shifts away from

private vehicle use are likely to depend on a broader combination of transport affordability, service quality, reliability and network accessibility.

7.2 Behavioural Change and Network-Level Outcomes

One of the most important findings emerging from this study is that behavioural change and traffic outcomes do not necessarily occur at the same scale or within the same time-frame.

Many respondents reported changing their travel behaviour, yet these changes translated into relatively modest network-level traffic impacts. This highlights the complexity of travel behaviour and reinforces the view that transport mode choice is influenced by multiple factors beyond cost alone.

The results also demonstrate that attracting passengers to public transport and retaining them over the longer term are likely to depend on different factors. While fare reductions can encourage experimentation and increase public transport use, sustained mode shift will depend heavily on service quality, reliability, comfort, frequency and accessibility.

The study therefore provides evidence that fare-based interventions can play an important role in transport policy, but are unlikely to achieve large-scale mode shift in isolation.

7.3 Policy Implications

From a policy perspective, the findings suggest that Victoria's free public transport initiative largely achieved its primary objective as a cost-of-living measure. The policy was widely supported by survey respondents and encouraged greater use of public transport during a period of economic pressure.

At the same time, the results highlight the importance of considering transport affordability alongside broader investments in service quality and network capacity. Improving public transport accessibility, reliability and passenger experience may be equally important for achieving sustained behavioural change and reducing long-term dependence on private vehicles.

The findings also highlight important equity considerations. The benefits of fare reductions are likely to be greatest where high-quality public transport services already exist. For regional and outer suburban communities, affordability improvements may need to be accompanied by enhanced service provision to maximise policy effectiveness.

7.4 Next Phase of the Evaluation

This report represents the first stage of an ongoing evaluation program examining the impacts of transport fare reforms in Victoria during 2026.

Following the conclusion of the free fare period, Victoria transitioned to a 50% public transport fare reduction that will remain in place for the remainder of the year. This creates an opportunity to examine whether the behavioural changes observed during the free fare period persist, strengthen or diminish under a discounted fare structure.

Future phases of the project will incorporate additional traffic monitoring data, updated survey evidence and other relevant transport datasets as they become available. These analyses will provide a more comprehensive understanding of the long-term effects of transport affordability measures on travel behaviour, public transport use and road network performance.

Closing Reflections

Victoria's 2026 public transport fare reforms represent one of the largest transport pricing interventions undertaken in Australia in recent years. The findings presented in this report suggest that reducing public transport costs can influence travel behaviour and encourage greater use of public transport, but that lasting shifts away from private vehicles will require a broader combination of pricing, service quality and network improvements. As the Victorian experiment continues, ongoing monitoring will provide valuable evidence for policymakers, transport agencies and researchers seeking to better understand the relationship between transport affordability and travel behaviour.

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